

Resume Optimization Guide

Applicant Tracking Systems (ATS) Manual • 5 Min Read

1. Understanding ATS Scanners

Applicant Tracking Systems (ATS) are software applications used by recruiters to organize, search, and rank job applications. Over 90% of Fortune 500 companies use an ATS to filter out candidates before a human even views the application.

To pass these automated filters, your resume must be structured logically, using standard text blocks and headings that parser algorithms can index cleanly.

2. Standard Formatting Rules

- **Layout Structure:** Always use a single-column layout. Multi-column structures frequently confuse parsers, causing them to merge unrelated text segments.
- **Bullet points:** Use standard round bullet markers. Do not use special design icons or arrows, which algorithms can read as un-indexable characters.
- **File type:** Export your resume as a standard PDF format. Ensure the text inside remains copy-pasteable (do not save your resume as a scanned image PDF).
- **Graphics and tables:** Completely avoid tables, text boxes, progress meters, and graphic icons. Visual decorations are ignored by parsers and often corrupt the text alignment.

3. Keyword Optimization Strategy

ATS matching scores are calculated based on how closely your resume matches the job description keywords.

- **Find target terms:** Carefully analyze the job listing. Note recurring skill nouns, tools, and job-specific verbs.
- **Placement:** Integrate these exact terms directly into your work experience bullet points. Do not stack keywords in a hidden list, as modern semantic search models flag keyword stuffing.